Republic of the Philippines
Bangsamoro Autonomous Region in Muslim Mindanao
BANGSAMORO TRANSITION AUTHORITY PARLIAMENT
Bangsamoro Government Center, Cotabato City

THIRD REGULAR SESSION

PARLIAMENT RESOLUTION NO. 536

RESOLUTION HONORING AND PAYING TRIBUTE TO FORMER SENATOR DR. SANTANINA "NINA" TILLAH RASUL FOR HER EXEMPLARY CONTRIBUTIONS TO WOMEN EMPOWERMENT, THE PEACE PROCESS, AND AUTONOMY, WHILE ENCOURAGING THE CONTINUATION OF HER ADVOCACY FOR REDUCING ADULT ILLITERACY IN THE BANGSAMORO AUTONOMOUS REGION IN MUSLIM MINDANAO

WHEREAS, former Senator Dr. Santanina "Nina" Tillah Rasul, the first Muslim woman to serve in the Philippine Senate, was born on September 14, 1930, in Siasi, Sulu, and passed away on November 28, 2024, at the age of ninety-four (94). She was a consistent valedictorian from elementary to secondary education, graduating from Laum Tabawan Elementary School in 1941 to Sulu High School in 1948, respectively. She earned her Bachelor of Arts in Political Science degree with a Latin award as *cum laude* from the University of the Philippines in 1952, obtained a master's degree in National Security Administration from the National Defense College of the Philippines in 1976, and eventually completed her doctoral units in Public Administration at the University of the Philippines in 1978;

WHEREAS, former Senator Dr. Nina Rasul's public service career spanned several decades, beginning as a public school teacher in Siasi and Jolo from 1952 to 1957. She then served as a technical assistant to the Office of the Philippines from 1963 to 1964. She was elected to two terms as a Barrio Councilor in Jolo, serving from 1960 to 1961 and 1962 to 1963. Additionally, she was elected to the Provincial Board of Sulu from 1971 to 1976. From 1978 to 1987, she was appointed as a commissioner representing Muslim and other ethnic minorities, and in 1986, became a member of the board at the Ministry of Education, Culture, and Sports.

WHEREAS, she served as the first Muslim woman senator from 1987 to 1995, making her the first and only Muslim woman senator elected and the first Muslim senator to be re-elected to the Senate. During her tenure, she served as Chairperson of the Senate Committee on Civil Service and Government Recognitions and the Committee on Women and Family Relations. She sponsored landmark legislation, including: Republic Act No. 6850, which grants civil service eligibility to long-serving government employees; Republic Act No. 6949, which declares March 8 as National Women's Day; Republic Act No. 7192, which dismantles gender discrimination and opens military opportunities for women; Republic Act No. 7168, which elevates Philippine Normal College to university status; and Republic Act No. 7165, which establishes the Literacy Coordinating Council to promote literacy and coordinate efforts to eradicate illiteracy in the Philippines. In recognition of her commitment to civil service reform and advocacy for government employees' rights, she received the prestigious Tandang Sora Award in 2019;

WHEREAS, she was a pivotal figure in peacebuilding, serving as a member of the government panel that forged the Peace Agreement with the Moro National Liberation Front (MNLF). Her contribution earned her the Golden Heart Presidential Award in 1998 and led to her election as a Fellow of the World Academy of Arts and Science in 1997. She was also a dedicated advocate for women`s empowerment, founding the first Muslim women's organization in the Philippines in the 1960s and organizing the Muslim Women Peace Advocates in 2001 to support peace and conflict resolution. Through her efforts, she helped establish *Noorus Salam,* or the Light of Peace, which is a national network of Muslim women leaders promoting human rights, peace advocacy, and humanitarian work;

WHEREAS, former Senator Dr. Nina Rasul made significant contributions to the advancement of literacy and education in the Philippines. While in public service, she founded the Magbassa Kita Foundation, Inc. (MKFI) in 1991, which aimed to combat illiteracy among adults by providing non-formal education to those who have missed formal schooling. Its flagship program, Literacy for Peace and Development (LIPAD), has empowered over sixty-seven thousand (67,000) neo-literate adults in the past four years of operation, eighty-five percent (85%) of whom are women. The program empowered thousands of Filipinos, particularly in the Bangsamoro region, benefiting rural, indigenous, and Muslim communities by equipping them with essential reading, writing, and arithmetic skills;

WHEREAS, her legislative efforts, including the authorship of Republic Act No. 7165, which established the Literacy Coordinating Council, demonstrate her commitment to providing policy direction for literacy promotion across the country;

WHEREAS, former Senator Dr. Nina Rasul's recognition as an Honorary Ambassador by the United Nations Educational, Scientific and Cultural Organization (UNESCO) during the International Literacy Year in 1990 underscores her influential role in promoting global literacy initiatives;

WHEREAS, despite significant efforts to improve literacy, adult illiteracy remains a pressing challenge in the Bangsamoro Autonomous Region in Muslim Mindanao (BARMM), where recent data indicate that approximately one-third of adults cannot read or write, thereby limiting opportunities for individual empowerment and regional development;

WHEREAS, according to the 2019 Functional Literacy, Education, and Mass Media Survey, BARMM recorded a basic literacy rate of only seventy-eight-point seven percent (78.7%), which is the lowest among all regions in the Philippines and significantly below the national average of ninety-four percent (94%). This disparity highlights ongoing challenges in education and access to learning resources within the region;

WHEREAS, literacy and education are universally recognized as fundamental to fostering economic growth, social cohesion, and sustainable peace, as they equip individuals with the skills to participate meaningfully in governance, livelihoods, and community-building activities, thereby fostering a more inclusive society;

WHEREAS, in honor of former Senator Dr. Santanina *"Nina"* Tillah Rasul's advocacy for literacy and education, this resolution supports the continued efforts to address high illiteracy rates in the BARMM, recognizing that improved literacy is pivotal to fostering better employment opportunities, enhanced civic engagement, community resilience, and the empowerment of women and all communities within the Bangsamoro Autonomous Region:

NOW, THEREFORE, be it

RESOLVED, as it is hereby resolved by the Bangsamoro Transition Authority Parliament, To honor and pay tribute to former senator Dr. Santanina *"Nina"* Tillah Rasul for her exemplary contributions to women empowerment, the peace process, and autonomy, while encouraging the continuation of her advocacy for reducing adult illiteracy in the Bangsamoro Autonomous Region in Muslim Mindanao.

RESOLVED, FURTHER, To encourage the Ministry of Basic, Higher, and Technical Education (MBHTE), Ministry of Indigenous People's Affairs (MIPA), and other relevant ministries, agencies, and offices to continue former Senator Rasul's advocacy for reducing adult illiteracy in the Bangsamoro Autonomous Region in Muslim Mindanao by implementing and supporting targeted literacy programs and initiatives.

RESOLVED, FINALLY, To furnish a copy of this resolution to the bereaved family of former Senator Rasul as an expression of our deepest condolences and recognition, as well as to MBHTE, MIPA, and other relevant ministries, agencies, and offices for appropriate consideration and action.

ADOPTED, *Sha'ban* 18, 1446/February 17, 2025.

Certified Correct:

PROF. RABY B. ANGKAL
Secretary-General

Attested:

ATTY. PANGALIAN M. BALINDONG
Speaker

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